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THE BOY AND BOB

FOR TWO decades, I've been questioned about consistency. It's a subject that's been written about extensively. There have been debates about whether I was always immature at batting, whether I had the self-discipline required to stay at the crease for long.

Here's my side of the story. When I started playing in U-14 and U-16 cricket, I was a bowler. At the U-19 level, I batted at number seven or eight. Then, on my international debut, though I was inducted into the team as a bowler, God helped me set that batting record – the fastest century the game had seen at the time – which changed things. In fact, it changed everything.

Unfortunately, from thereon, I was slotted as a batsman, not a kid who bowls fast googlies and is useful with the bat too. I always was, and still remain, the latter. In hindsight, I know what really happened. That ODI century in Nairobi changed two things – perceptions and expectations. Moreover, it changed me – my focus shifted from bowling to batting. Simply put, it changed the direction of my career and my life. Right from the beginning, I had to respond to the surge in expectations, and that was tough.

Walking in to a stadium and hearing people screaming *'Chhakka!* (Sixer!)' takes a toll on you, especially when you know you're simply a bowler who can bat on the trot. So, slowly, I tried to transition into a batsman. I was credited for a talent I didn't really possess. It was like being hired for a skill I wasn't exactly trained in. A kid who has always batted happily at number seven or eight, way down the order, is all of a sudden expected to open the innings against the bowling greats of the world. It was not easy – maybe it wasn't even the right thing to do, either – but I carried on, as that's what the job demanded.

Soon, I started seeing structural problems in my batting and reality hit home about how my overall performance was panning out. The biggest one, admittedly, was consistency. I couldn't be consistent. Not with my style and temperament. To give you an analogy of what was going wrong: if you know your weapons, you will agree that machine guns fire the fastest but get jammed the most, compared to other arms. Their rate of fire is both their strength and their